

4.1 Chat Clients

4.1.1 Google Talk

Among the major players in this segment, Google is a comparatively late entrant. It started off with a downloadable client called Gtalk, which enabled users to chat and make voice calls. Google also enabled the chat functionality from inside Gmail. This proved to be wildly popular because people did not need to do messy installs and configure settings: just click on the contact once you were in, and start talking with your Gmail contacts.

After downloading the client from www.google.com/talk, select **Settings > Connection** and enter the network settings. Sign in using your Gmail username and password and you are all set! Google uses the open source Jabber protocol for its chat services.

For configuring the look and feel of the chat window, select **Settings > Appearance** and choose the chat themes from the drop-down. Each theme has a preview; choose the one you like and click OK. Another way to change the way your contacts are displayed in your Friends list is by using the View button. You can enable all your contacts to be seen even when they are offline, or to only see online contacts. Additionally, you can see all your online contacts or just a few of them, by clicking on the Show one page option.

Gtalk is tightly integrated with Orkut. If your contact is online on Orkut, you can scrap him / her from inside Gtalk. Viewing the Orkut profile from inside Gtalk is also possible. If the contact is not online, you can send voicemail messages. These will appear in the Gmail Inbox of the receiver, and can be heard as an MP3 file. Any voicemail pending for you is indicated by a green phone icon.

For making calls from inside Gtalk, click on any name from your list. If that person is online using Gtalk (contacts can show up in the list if they are logged in to Gmail and has chat enabled), and if the Talk option appears, click on the button and make a call. File transfers in Gtalk are pretty fast, and there is no restriction on file size. The transfer is peer-to-peer and pretty fast.

For chat inside Gmail, there are several features that are not available in Gtalk. One is the ability to hold a group chat (with more than one person); another is the new Flash smileys that comple-